year or so before he celebrated Shivratri with the yogis, Akbar sketched out a plan of action for the months (not years) to come. First, he would go east and 'found a great city' in Prayag, it being 'regarded by the people of India with much reverence', stay awhile and calm the region. Next, he would travel south and conquer the Deccan, 'which was longing for a just ruler', ride on towards Turan, to deal with his brother Hakim once and for all, and sort out matters between his ageing uncle Sulaiman and Sulaiman's grandson Shahrukh, still feuding over Badakhshan. And thus, come full circle, Akbar would recover 'the land of his ancestors'.[4]

Akbar announced these plans in the month of his forty-first birthday. If Fathullah's calculations were to be believed, he was barely one-third of the way through his life, and if Akbar meant to conquer his ancestral Samarqand that very year, one wonders what he had planned for the decades that remained to him.

In fact, however, Akbar was closer to the end of his life than to the beginning. He had a little over twenty years left; and while, in the early 1580s, the emperor was at the very height of his power, showing every sign of blazing through the second quarter of his reign as he had through the first, a sense of ending runs through the annals of these years, as death begins to haunt the emperor: not only the fear of his own, but the actual, accumulating demise of the people who filled his world – his enemies, including Rana Pratap and, in Kabul, Mirza Hakim; his friends, from Todar Mal to Fathullah and Birbar; and, most tragically, his children.

~

Once, for Akbar to have an idea was to execute it: whether to gallop after Adham Khan in Malwa or set sail in the monsoon after Daud. Now, somehow, though Akbar was stronger than ever before, his plans were more fallible. Thus, of his three stated ambitions for 1583–84, his twenty-eighth year on the throne – a city in Prayag, the conquest of the Deccan and the recovery of Samarqand – Akbar only managed one. Barely four weeks after announcing his plans, Akbar did, indeed, arrive in Prayag, 'that place of worship',[5] and establish the city known as Illahbas, 'God's abode'. It would be almost two decades, however, in the very last years of his life, before Akbar descended upon the Deccan. As for any hope of banging Sulaiman